

CHAPTER 39

SEL in Countries Affected by Armed Conflicts and Protracted Crises

Ha Yeon Kim, Rena Deitz, and J. Lawrence Aber

In 2023, approximately 224 million school-age children worldwide were affected by armed conflicts and protracted crises (Education Cannot Wait [ECW], 2023). This number is expected to rise due to ongoing events in 2023 and 2024, such as the Russian invasion of Ukraine, which has displaced nearly 10 million people and put 2.9 million children in need inside Ukraine (UNHCR, 2024; UN International Children's Education Fund [UNICEF], 2024); the earthquakes in Turkey and Syria, which devastated nearly 18 million individuals (Omer, 2023); conflict in Sudan, which displaced 4 million Sudanese children (OHCHR, 2024); and the unfolding Israel–Hamas conflict displacing 1.7 million Palestinians in Gaza—half of them children (OCHA, 2024). These children in contexts affected by conflict and crisis (CAC) endure tremendous adversities, including exposure to violence, trauma, displacement, and harsh and unpredictable living conditions. It is evident that living through such crises endangers children's mental health and compromises their academic and social and emotional development (Arakelyan & Ager, 2021; Cummings et al., 2017).

The global humanitarian sector has enthusiastically embraced school-based universal social and emotional learning (SEL)

interventions as a strategy to bolster resilience, proactively address risks, and develop necessary social and emotional competencies (SECs) in CAC contexts (Global Education Monitoring Report [GEMR], 2019). Although SEL programs have been widely implemented and evaluated in stable high-income contexts for nearly five decades (Cipriano et al., 2023; Durlak et al., 2011, 2022), only in the last decade have they begun to be adapted, used, and evaluated in CAC contexts (Deitz et al., 2021). However, SEL programming, design, implementation, and research are hampered by the scarcity of rigorous research on how children from different cultures and populations develop and learn SECs, and how conflict and crises impact their development. CAC contexts encompass diverse cultures, values, and priorities, and their education systems, schools, teachers, and students face immense challenges. Applying the SEL intervention paradigm that is primarily based on research from sociopolitically stable, economically developed, and Western cultural contexts to CAC contexts requires a critical reexamination of assumptions and rigorous contextualization, and testing of program design, implementation, and evaluation.

This chapter examines how the current dominant SEL paradigm is adopted, adapt-

ed, challenged, and/or expanded in CAC contexts. We then propose opportunities for enhancing and transforming SEL programming and research at large, drawing on emerging research in such contexts. The following sections (1) define the scope of CAC contexts; (2) summarize a brief history of SEL and existing evidence in CAC contexts; (3) discuss efforts to address challenges in designing, implementing, and studying SEL in CAC contexts; (4) identify opportunities to advance the field; and (5) highlight five key takeaway messages.

Defining CAC Contexts

This chapter focuses on universal SEL programming in education settings, encompassing formal, informal, and nonformal education systems and programs designed or adapted for children affected by armed conflict and protracted crises in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs), where access to education and basic services are impeded (ECW, 2023). Types of conflicts and crises that impact children's learning and development range from interstate and intrastate armed conflicts, contested governance, civil strife, and climate-related disasters, to other crises such as earthquakes and pandemics. The majority of refugees and internally displaced people (IDP) fleeing these conflicts and crises seek refuge in neighboring regions and countries—which are mostly LMICs and are often also affected by conflict and crisis, which strains the host communities' capacity to provide quality education and services for both displaced and host community children. The effects on education systems and children's well-being vary depending on the nature of the crisis, levels of violence and criminality, state legitimacy, governance structure, available economic resources, and other contextual elements. In many cases, states experience multiple crises that compound over time. For instance, Lebanon, which in 2023 hosted the highest per capita refugee population globally, has endured a prolonged history of civil war, armed conflicts, multiple waves of refugee influx, recent political unrest following the Beirut Explosion, economic collapse, and the COVID-19 pandemic. These compounded and protracted crises further

compromise and complicate the provision of services to support children's learning and well-being.

SEL in CAC Contexts: Brief History and Extant Evidence

Conducting rigorous program evaluation research in CAC settings is highly challenging for a variety of reasons, including the unpredictable nature of the context, the urgency of needs, limited research capacity and resources, coordination challenges among stakeholders, and ethical concerns such as research designs that restrict access to potentially beneficial services for vulnerable populations. Despite these difficulties, SEL research has gained momentum in CAC contexts over the past decade.

A Brief History of the Rise of SEL in CAC Contexts

The prioritization of SEL in education in CAC contexts originated from the need to mitigate the adverse effects of conflict on children's development and learning. Early interventions arose under the umbrella of mental health and psychosocial support (MHPSS), focused on promoting psychosocial well-being and addressing mental health problems (Inter-Agency Standing Committee, 2007). Although some MHPSS interventions showed positive effects on mental health, the benefits were often limited to subgroups, such as girls, while showing null or negative impacts for others (Jordans et al., 2016). In addition, despite being implemented within education settings, most of these programs did not target academic learning.

As evidence from the high-income, stable contexts grew more convincing about the positive impacts of SEL interventions for improving both social and emotional outcomes and longer-term outcomes such as well-being and academic achievement (Cipriano et al., 2023; Durlak et al., 2011, 2022), humanitarian stakeholders turned their attention to SEL. SEL differed from MHPSS in that it was specifically designed for education, emphasizing holistic learning and skills development (Inter-Agency Network for Education in Emergencies [INEE], 2016). In practice, however, MHPSS and SEL are often grouped together and used interchangeably.

The increasing popularity of SEL in the humanitarian sector has led to the rapid growth of research on the topic, mainly through research–practice partnerships between implementing organizations and researchers (Aber et al., 2021) to address the scarcity of evidence on education interventions in CAC contexts and promote equitable knowledge generation (Shah et al., 2024). Deitz and colleagues’ (2021) systematic review of SEL in humanitarian and development settings identified 49 unique SEL interventions in humanitarian settings as of 2021. Yet the quality and overall quantity of the evidence on these interventions remain limited. To date, most of the research has focused on *which SEL approaches work* in CAC contexts, and *for whom*.

SEL Approaches in CAC Contexts

SEL programming in CAC contexts tends to focus on changing the classroom climate or providing direct skills instruction, or combining these two approaches (Aber et al., 2021; Cipriano et al., 2023). Climate-targeted SEL programs focus on creating a safe and supportive learning environment conducive to developing SECs by incorporating positive classroom practices within academic educational programming, without explicitly teaching specific SEL skills. Skill-targeted SEL programs, in contrast, explicitly aim to develop SECs, employing stand-alone SEL lessons or activities, or integrating SEL content within academic instruction.

Early SEL in CAC contexts was primarily *climate targeted*. Creating a safe and supportive learning environment is seen as a fundamental prerequisite for fostering SECs, as well as academic and mental health outcomes (Aber et al., 2021; Cipriano et al., 2023). In conflict-affected contexts, where basic safety and predictability cannot be taken for granted, achieving these preconditions requires significant programmatic support, training, and considerable efforts from teachers. Attaining such conditions, let alone ensuring their transfer to SEL, presents a challenging endeavor for schools and teachers operating under extreme constraints. Emerging evidence suggests that climate-targeted interventions can enhance children’s perception of safety and support in the

classroom in CAC contexts; yet it is unclear if climate-targeted SEL alone can improve children’s SECs (Aber et al., 2021; Lasater et al., 2022). One example of climate-targeted SEL is the International Rescue Committee’s Learning in a Healing Classroom (LIHC), which incorporates classroom practices aligned with SEL principles, such as creating an intellectually stimulating environment, fostering a sense of control, and promoting a sense of belonging. Across contexts, LIHC has demonstrated positive impacts on its target outcomes: improving children’s perception of the classroom climate (Torrente et al., 2019; Tubbs Dolan et al., 2022) and their academic outcomes (Brown et al., 2022; Torrente et al., 2019; Tubbs Dolan et al., 2022). Yet, it showed no impact on mental health (Torrente et al., 2019; Tubbs Dolan et al., 2022), which was considered a critical distal outcome. Evaluations of climate-targeted SELs in CACs rarely measure SECs, making it challenging to understand the specific mechanisms through which they impact academic and mental health outcomes (Lasater et al., 2022).

On the other hand, recent research suggests that explicitly targeting social and emotional skills—that is, *skill targeted*—is necessary to achieve desired social and emotional outcomes (Aber et al., 2021; Cipriano et al., 2023). In CAC contexts, the evidence on skill-targeted SEL improving SEC and other outcomes is promising, though it has been somewhat mixed. Studies that compared the treatment group receiving both skill-targeted SEL and educational programming to a control group that received no programming reported positive impacts on academic outcomes but not on SECs, for example, in Northeast Nigeria and Uganda (Diazgranados et al., 2022; NORC News, 2020). However, in these cases, it is possible the positive impacts on academic outcomes are the results of educational programming rather than the SEL component.

Other evaluations of skill-targeted SEL in CAC contexts report positive impacts, or at least promising trends, of improving SECs. For example, the Better Learning Program 2 (BLP-2) implemented with low-performing students in Gaza led to significant improvements in well-being, self-regulation, self-efficacy, executive function, hope, and academic outcomes (Forsberg & Shultz,

2023). Several skill-targeted SEL interventions embedded within the LIHC remedial education programs have also shown promising results. Specifically, the Mindfulness activities had significant positive impacts on emotion regulation skills and marginally significant positive impacts on reactive aggression among local and refugee children affected by the Boko Haram crisis in Niger, when compared to LIHC alone (Kim et al., 2024); and marginally positive impacts on children's emotional and behavioral regulation skills for Syrian refugee children in Lebanon, when compared to a no-treatment control (Tubbs Dolan et al., 2022). Similarly, a skill-targeted SEL curriculum added to LIHC, when compared to LIHC alone, demonstrated positive trends in improving emotion knowledge, emotion and behavioral regulation, and prosocial behavior and academic engagement among Syrian refugee children (Kim et al., 2023).

Overall, climate-targeted SEL has shown positive impacts on creating safe and supportive learning environments in CACs, but improving SECs appears to require skill-targeted SEL (Aber et al., 2021), just as it is in stable, largely high-income contexts (Cipriano et al., 2023).

SEL for Whom?: Considering Vulnerable Populations in CAC Contexts

Adversities that children experience resulting from conflict and crises, such as violence and displacement, increase their vulnerability and can exacerbate existing inequalities and further marginalize already vulnerable populations. Research on MHPSS interventions has shown both benefits and harm to children's mental health, varying across subgroups such as gender, age, and heightened vulnerability, including exposure to violence, displacement, and abduction (Jordans et al., 2016): The same might be true for some SEL interventions. Given the potential for such heterogeneity of impact, SEL in CAC contexts must pay special attention to different subgroups.

Yet, existing research on SEL in CAC contexts rarely examines differential impacts on subgroups with heightened vulnerability (e.g., exposure to violence, mental health challenges, or low SECs and academic skills). Instead, the available evidence largely

focuses on disparities by easy-to-collect demographic characteristics (i.e., gender, age). However, the assumptions of vulnerability based on gender and age are often untested and do not consider children's actual experiences, often simplifying and misrepresenting existing variability and vulnerability.

Differential Impacts by Gender

The few available studies that have explored the heterogeneity of SEL intervention impact by gender present mixed results. Multiple studies have shown greater impacts for girls than boys (Deitz & Lahmann, 2023). For example, the School Mediation Intervention in Gaza, designed to enhance mental health and promote social functioning, led to a positive impact on prosocial behavior only among girls (Peltonen et al., 2012). Similarly, the Mindfulness activities programming in Niger led to greater gains for girls than for boys in emotion regulation, aggression, and school-related stress (Kim et al., 2024).

Other interventions have shown the opposite. For example, Classroom-Based Interventions (CBIs) focused on reducing psychosocial problems and facilitating resilience through enhancing coping, prosocial behavior, and hope, had significant positive impacts on psychological difficulties and aggression only among boys in conflict-affected rural Nepal (Jordans et al., 2010); and larger impacts on reducing emotional and behavioral difficulties for young Palestinian boys than girls (ages 6–11) in Gaza and the West Bank (Khamis et al., 2004).

Differential Impacts by Age

SEL interventions in CACs often target wide age ranges yet fail to disaggregate the effects by age. According to Deitz and Lahmann's (2023) recent review, studies generally indicate that SEL programs are more beneficial for younger children, although there are exceptions. For example, studies of Child-Friendly Spaces (CFSs) for Syrian refugees in Jordan revealed that young children attending CFSs reported reduced protection-related concerns and improved resilience. However, older adolescents in the same program reported an increased level of concerns and weakened resilience (Metzler et al., 2015). Similarly, while CBI in Gaza

and the West Bank had positive impacts on prosocial behavior for younger Palestinian children, it resulted in decreased coping skills and mechanisms for adolescents, with reports of feeling more burdened by difficult circumstances (Khamis et al., 2004). On the other hand, a similar CBI program increased a sense of hope among adolescents, but not among younger children, in Nepal (Jordans et al., 2010). These differential benefits by age group are not consistent across gender, contexts, nor SEL interventions, and more research is needed to understand developmental and gender-specific needs present in CACs (Deitz & Lahmann, 2023).

Differential Impacts by Vulnerability

Few SEL studies in CACs have examined differential impacts on subgroups with heightened vulnerability (e.g., exposure to violence, mental health challenges, and low SECs and academic skills). However, the existing evidence suggests there is minimal risk of harm and potential additional benefits of SEL for groups with heightened vulnerability. Studies either found no variation in SEL impacts based on exposure to violence and conflict (Kim et al., 2023) or refugee status (Brown et al., 2022), or that refugees and internally displaced children benefit more from SEL than the host community children (Kim et al., 2024; LASER PULSE, 2020). Further research on how to address the specific needs of the most vulnerable children will improve overall effectiveness and equity for populations that are the most affected by crisis and conflict.

Summary: What We Know and Don't Know So Far on SEL in CAC Contexts

Existing evidence suggests that certain SEL interventions, especially skill-targeted SEL, hold promise for improving children's SECs, psychosocial well-being, and academic outcomes in CAC contexts. However, not all SEL interventions have demonstrated such impacts. Research is only beginning to reveal what approaches work and for whom, and there is a need for more evidence in order to understand the mechanisms by which SEL interventions work, in what contexts, and how to effectively implement them in CAC

contexts—vital information to inform future program design and implementation (Aber et al., 2021; Lasater et al., 2022).

Addressing Challenges of SEL in CAC Contexts

With recognition of the gaps in the evidence and challenges of designing, adapting, and implementing SEL in CAC contexts, researchers and stakeholders are adopting innovative, context-relevant, and collaborative approaches to address these issues. This section highlights four efforts to advance SEL in CAC contexts.

Which SECs to Target?: Identifying High-Value SECs in Context

Effective SEL interventions should target SECs that are relevant to the target population and context. To do so, there is an increasing effort to define and identify universal and context-specific SECs in CAC contexts. While there may be universal SECs that support children's learning, development, and adaptation across cultures (Jones et al., 2020), how these competencies are perceived, valued, exhibited, and related to desired outcomes vary across cultures and subcultures, and different stakeholders (Jukes et al., 2021). These discrepancies necessitate a shared understanding of SECs, including both common and culture-specific, to take collective action to inform research, program development, and policy.

A further complication is the complexity of our current understanding of SECs themselves. The realm of SECs comprises large sets of different skills, processes, values, and outcomes that are intricately related to each other. The same processes or competencies often go by different conceptual names; and the same conceptual names are often used to denote different processes or competencies. Different names for key concepts have evolved because different communities and disciplines use different linguistic and theoretical frameworks to define and study aspects of SEL. For example, Jukes and colleagues (2021) found that the SECs highly valued in Tanzania, such as competencies related to social responsibility, were not represented in the CASEL's "Big Five" SECs.

The complexity, culturally different priorities, and inconsistent use of the terminologies in the field of SEL add confusion to the already-challenging decision of which SECs, for what population, in which culture and context, and for what purpose.

Efforts are under way to address these challenges within the SEL research and practice communities. First, the Taxonomy Project (<http://exploresel.gse.harvard.edu>; see Barnes et al., Chapter 28, this volume) aims to consolidate SEL terminology and frameworks to foster transparent communication and a common understanding of SECs. In partnership with INEE, Jones and colleagues (2020) extended this work to address the complexity of CAC settings (<http://inee.exploresel.gse.harvard.edu>).

Second, promising practices have emerged to engage local voices and ensure the relevance of SECs in development and humanitarian contexts (Bailey et al., 2021; Jukes et al., 2021). For example, Bailey and colleagues (2021) worked with teachers and Ministry of Education officials in Northeast Nigeria to identify priority SECs and developed and field-tested activities to ensure that they were relevant, applicable, and user-friendly. This collaborative approach, which started by identifying context-relevant SECs, fosters buy-in and increases the effectiveness and uptake of SEL interventions. This corroborates Jukes and colleagues' (2021) findings in Tanzania, where teachers preferred activities in which they had input compared to other activities.

Partnerships between local, national, and global stakeholders have also been instrumental in identifying and defining priority SECs that are responsive and relevant to the needs of contexts and populations. For example, in Lebanon, a national SEL framework was developed through a research–practice–policy partnership involving local and global stakeholders. This collaborative effort identified SECs that are both commonly valued in other contexts, such as inhibitory control and prosocial and cooperative behavior, and unique to the local context, such as “respect for the environment” and “flexibility” (Caires et al., 2022). These unique SECs reflect the local culture and the need to help children learn to respect and preserve social and physical surround-

ings, and adapt to changing environmental demands, especially in crisis situations. Similar work is continuing in Peru, in response to the Venezuelan refugee crisis (Peru Ministerio de Educación, 2022), and in East Africa (<https://reliafrica.org/alive>; Giacomazzi et al., 2022), where there are high levels of displacement. These efforts to devise valid, legitimate ways to identify priority SECs will need to expand to advance work on SEL in CAC contexts.

How Does SEL Work?: Theory of Change for SEL in CAC Contexts

Understanding mechanisms that drive change in SECs within SEL interventions is critical to inform and improve program design and implementation in any context. In CAC settings, where funding is limited and needs are greater, it is even more important to build theoretically grounded and empirically tested program theories of change to maximize program effectiveness and scale-up (Aber et al., 2021; Lasater et al., 2022). A well-defined theory of change links intervention components to target processes and outcomes, guides decision making on delivery and sequencing, and informs research decisions on what processes and outcomes are to be evaluated, when, and with whom (Lasater et al., 2022; Miller et al., 2021).

Unfortunately, thus far, there is little rigorous evidence available on the theory and mechanisms of change within SEL interventions in any context, much less in CACs (Aber et al., 2021; Lasater et al., 2022; Miller et al., 2021). A recent review of school-based MHPSS interventions in humanitarian contexts, which included SEL, found that very few studies specified a theory of change for their programs (Lasater et al., 2022). Many studies included outcomes that lacked theoretical justification and were inconsistent with SEL or psychosocial support frameworks (e.g., clinical symptoms of psychological distress, academic outcomes). This misalignment between targeted and evaluated outcomes hinders the understanding of effective SEL strategies that address the specific needs of CAC populations (Kim et al., 2023).

To address this gap, there is a growing demand for the conceptualization and

testing of theories of change and intervention mechanisms among donors, researchers, and practitioners (Lasater et al., 2022; Miller et al., 2021). Evaluation studies now increasingly include measures of targeted SECs (e.g., Forsberg & Shultz, 2023; Kim et al., 2023). Future initiatives would benefit from developing program theories of change with stakeholders in each context to ensure that the content and design are appropriate, relevant, and reflective of the context and culture (Bailey et al., 2021; Lasater et al., 2022).

How to Make SEL Work Better?: Implementation Research in CAC Contexts

Rigorous implementation studies of SEL programming in crisis-affected contexts are even rarer than high-quality impact evaluations. While the key dimensions of implementation of SEL interventions—content, delivery modes, fidelity, dosage, quality, and so forth—are as important in CAC contexts as in high-income stable contexts, the assumptions underlying the analysis of implementation may differ due to unique contextual constraints. Organizational and resource challenges in CAC contexts, such as chaos and turmoil within schools and nonformal education programs—within which SEL interventions are implemented—may diminish the relevance of the SAFE (sequenced, active, focused, explicit) criteria for quality implementation that have been associated with positive impacts in stable high-income contexts (Cipriano et al., 2023; Durlak et al., 2011). For instance, sequenced SEL interventions that systematically build skills in a logical order are most effective in high-income stable contexts (Durlak et al., 2011). However, assumptions in stable contexts that students can and will *consistently* attend the *full duration* of programming to benefit from a sequenced intervention are not reasonable in CAC contexts. Program attendance is often substantially lower and more variable in low-income and conflict-affected contexts (Roby et al., 2016). Attendance rates as low as 40–60% have been reported in studies conducted in Niger and Lebanon (Brown et al., 2022; Kim et al., 2023; Tubbs Dolan et al., 2022). Children's attendance is affected by the competing priorities that they and their families must

navigate, such as safety, seasonal labor, continued mobility, and caregiving responsibilities. They are therefore unlikely to reap the full benefits of SEL programs due to reduced dosage and disruptions in program sequence and continuity.

Implementers working in CACs are aware of the challenges and potential benefits of increasing attendance. They employ various strategies to encourage children's participation, including providing transportation, sending out weekly reports, fostering parent involvement through events and dialogues, and checking on absent children via phone calls and messages (Akar, 2015; Kim et al., 2023). However, even the mere monitoring of attendance at the individual level is resource-intensive and challenging in contexts with limited data infrastructure. Finding solutions to systematic attendance tracking, along with further research on constraints to attendance and strategies to increase attendance, are essential to enhance program effectiveness (Brown et al., 2022). Ongoing research has begun to examine innovative delivery designs that identify and address barriers in implementation to mitigate the impact of frequent absenteeism, such as utilizing brief and repeatable activities (Bailey et al., 2021; Kim et al., 2024; Wu et al., 2023).

Other frequently mentioned challenges to implementation include security threats, resource constraints, teacher absenteeism, lack of continuity and sustainability of access to education, and lack of community buy-in, to name a few. Weaker education data systems and greater financial constraints impede the comprehensive study of implementation. Given the limited resources and time available for programming in CAC contexts, it is even more important to maximize the effectiveness of SEL interventions by improving implementation through innovative and context-relevant program delivery and implementation designs, systematic and rapid prototyping and piloting, collaboration and co-creation with local actors, and comprehensive support for teachers and facilitators (Aber et al., 2021; Bailey et al., 2021; Kim et al., 2024). These various program implementation strategies should be explicitly and systematically tested and documented by using research designs that can identify solutions that maximize program impact and economic value.

How Do We Accurately Capture the Impact?: SEL Measurement in CAC Contexts

Building a robust evidence base on SEL in CAC contexts requires measures that align with the program theory of change, demonstrate sound psychometric properties, are contextually appropriate, and can be feasibly implemented given limited resources and time for assessment (Tubbs Dolan & Caïres, 2020). However, measuring SEL in any, and especially CAC, context presents significant challenges. A recent meta-analysis (Cipriano et al., 2023) identified more than 1,800 outcomes across 258 SEL evaluations, largely from high-income stable countries, yet less than half of the studies reported reliability and validity evidence of the measures used. Moreover, these studies used the same measures to capture different SEL constructs and different measures to capture the same constructs. This lack of consensus and systematic guidelines for SEL measurement even in stable contexts further complicates the selection and development of measures in culturally and contextually diverse CAC settings (Jones et al., 2020).

Another complicating factor is the intended purpose of assessing and evaluating SEL programming. SEL programs in CAC contexts are often implemented by nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) or governments and supported by external funders, and assessment is primarily carried out to fulfill donor reporting requirements. Due to limited resources and funding and practicality, readily available tools that are familiar and easy to use for monitoring and reporting purposes take precedence over the methodological rigor necessary to measure SECs in high-quality evaluation research that allows for causal inference.

As a result, SEL research in conflict and crisis contexts has historically relied on “off-the-shelf” measures used without sufficient consideration of their intended purpose or their reliability and validity in the target population and context (Tubbs Dolan, 2017). However, most of these measures were developed in stable, high-income Western contexts with different cultural and contextual assumptions. For example, the Strengths and Difficulties Questionnaire (Goodman, 2001), a frequently used measure in SEL research in both stable and CAC

contexts due to its practicality and simplicity (Cipriano et al., 2023; Deitz et al., 2021), was initially developed and validated in the United Kingdom but has limited psychometric evidence of reliability and validity in non-U.K. contexts, especially in CAC contexts (Jones et al., 2020; Tubbs Dolan, 2017). Using existing measures without assessing their psychometric properties and cultural and contextual fit not only increases measurement error and underestimates the effectiveness of programming but also poses a significant threat to the validity of the SEL research in these contexts (Aber, 2019).

Efforts are under way to develop, adapt, and test SEL measures in CACs, such as the INEE Measurement Library (<https://inee.org/measurement-library>) and the UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) Humanitarian Education Accelerator (<https://www.unhcr.org/hea>). However, these initiatives are still in their early stages and require further support to ensure the SEL measures with strong psychometric evidence and cultural- and contextual relevance are used, tested, and replicated across different cultures and contexts and to develop a robust library of SEC measures that cover the full range of SEL intervention outcomes.

Leaping Forward: Next Frontiers of SEL in CAC Contexts

Building a Systematic and Cumulative Evidence Base in CAC Contexts for SEL

SEL research in CAC contexts currently lacks a coherent approach to generate a systematic and cumulative evidence base. Inconsistencies in research are driven by different focal processes and outcomes, wide-ranging delivery and implementation approaches, diverse contexts and populations, and the complexity of defining SECs. The result is a difficult-to-synthesize evidence base (e.g., education intervention only assessing academic outcomes or mental health intervention only assessing mental health and overlooking SECs). Such a situation poses enormous challenges in generating evidence-based SEL program and policy decisions.

The field of SEL also has a lot of work ahead to advance the understanding of how social and emotional skills and processes

manifest and interact with a broader ecological context in which children grow up, including insecurity and adversity in CAC contexts. The conditions and underlying assumptions from stable, high-income, Western contexts may not hold in CAC contexts. Instead, we need to build a comprehensive understanding of what SECs look like and how SEL can support adaptation and well-being across homes, schools, communities, and broader society and culture in CAC contexts. Recent research has begun to explore how different SECs are valued, perceived, manifested, and affected by experiences and environments in different CAC contexts, as discussed earlier (Caires et al., 2022; Jukes et al., 2021; Peru Ministerio de Educación, 2022). However, the diversity of experiences, cultures, settings, and populations in CAC contexts, coupled with the general scarcity of research in child development and learning in relevant contexts, renders the current state of evidence insufficient to achieve culturally and contextually responsive and high-quality program design and implementation.

In short, as SEL programming and research rapidly increase in CAC contexts, the field needs a systematic understanding of the state of evidence based on a well-defined and comprehensive conceptual framework (e.g., Kim et al., 2022) to translate individual studies into an interconnected body of knowledge that can advance research, programming, and policy.

Supporting Teachers' SEL in CAC Contexts

Competent and capable teachers are the most integral part of supporting children's SEL and academic learning in educational settings. Yet few supports are available to help teachers build the complex skills sets to implement SEL programs effectively, including pedagogical, social, and emotional skills. In CACs, education systems are further weakened by instability, restricted resources, and forced migration, and teachers are forced to don many hats—educator, translator, counselor, administrator, nurse, and at times, protector and defender (Dryden-Peterson, 2011). Teachers in CACs navigate multiple demands while coping with extraordinary challenges themselves, including inadequate and/or inconsistent pay, poverty, safety con-

cerns, and other disruptions in family and social networks. In schools, they cope with large class sizes, lack of teaching materials, inadequate infrastructure, frequent school closings, and limited school leadership. In communities, they navigate security threats, norms that devalue the roles of teachers, and sometimes explicit threats to educational institutions (Schwartz et al., 2019).

However, teachers rarely have access to support for addressing barriers in their personal and professional lives (Nemiro et al., 2022). The resulting stress and burnout affect teacher attendance, attrition, and the quality of pedagogical and classroom practices, ultimately affecting their ability to provide effective education and SEL programming (Hoglund et al., 2015). In the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC), teachers' stress and perceptions of risk are associated with burnout and dissatisfaction (Wolf et al., 2015). In Lebanon, Syrian refugee teachers report their struggle with high levels of stress, helplessness, and a loss of hope in their personal lives as refugees, despite feeling a sense of purpose and accomplishment as educators (Adelman, 2019).

While efforts to support teacher SEL and mental health are under way in high-income contexts (Jennings et al., 2017), such initiatives are only beginning to emerge in CAC contexts. Teacher support programming in CAC contexts primarily aims to improve teachers' technical capacities rather than improve their own SECs and well-being. Although many teachers report benefits from these supports (Lodi, 2019), such an approach can be ineffective and even harmful if it fails to consider teachers' individual needs, vulnerabilities, and the cultural and contextual factors they navigate (Nemiro et al., 2022). For example, Learning in a Healing Classroom, a climate-targeted SEL intervention with a teacher peer-support component, had negative effects on the mental health and job satisfaction of female teachers (Wolf et al., 2015) and teachers in schools directly affected by conflict in DRC (Frisoli, 2014). These results were attributed to the negative experience of participation in teacher peer support groups that reinforced cultural gender norms and did not address teachers' physical, social, and emotional needs.

There have been notable efforts to develop and implement programs that support teach-

ers' SEL and well-being, such as War Child's Coaching–Observing–Reflecting–Engaging (CORE) for Teachers (Coetzee, 2019) and FHI 360's Social Emotional Development for Teachers (Hahn, 2019). However, these teacher-targeted SEL programs are often deprioritized and lack funding despite their critical importance. Building a capable, motivated, and socially and emotionally competent teacher workforce in CACs is key to transforming SEL into an effective and sustainable practice, and it merits substantial attention, investment, and research.

Policy and SEL: Systemic and Sustainable SEL in CAC Contexts

To help children and adults cope with the challenges of living in CAC contexts at scale, stakeholders need to go beyond discrete SEL programs and strive toward “systemic SEL,” which involves “aligned policies, resources, and actions at state and district levels that encourage local schools and communities to build the personal and professional capabilities of adults to implement and continuously improve evidence-based programs and practices; create an inclusive culture that fosters caring relationships and youth voice, agency, and character; and support coordinated school–family–community partnerships to enhance student development” (Mahoney et al., 2021, p. 1129). Evidence is mounting in the United States that SEL interventions are more effective when integrated into a comprehensive education system that supports and promotes SEL (CASEL, 2020). However, building integrated systems is even more challenging in CAC contexts and, as of now, there are no reported examples of truly systemic SEL in these contexts.

Nevertheless, a similar concept of “policy–practice coherence” in the education systems is gaining momentum in LMICs (Kaffenberger & Spivack, 2022) and CAC contexts (Kim et al., 2022; Tubbs Dolan, 2017). This approach emphasizes the alignment of various stakeholders within the education system (e.g., governing authorities, formal and nonformal schools, donors, multilateral organizations, international and local NGOs, schools, teachers and service providers, communities, parents, students) based on data and evidence. Systemic SEL addresses similar issues by identifying the

necessary systems to optimize the impact of SEL programming on both SECs and academic outcomes. The emerging bodies of literature on both systemic SEL and on policy–practice coherence underscore the importance of aligning policies, resources, and actions at the school, community, and regional/national levels with SEL goals.

SEL policies and practices also must align with the contexts in which they occur by effectively addressing the cultural and unique needs of children and educators affected by crises. However, the donor–recipient power dynamics of humanitarian aid often result in donor-driven priorities. The rise of SEL interventions in CAC contexts is, in fact, largely propelled by key donor agencies and global convening bodies based in stable Western contexts, such as the U.S. Agency for International Development (USAID; 2019) and INEE (2016). While these investments and prioritization have contributed to the rapid growth of support and research in the holistic learning and development of children affected by CACs, donor-driven priorities do not necessarily align with the local culture or address the most pressing community needs. In addition, this approach often leads to the transplantation and implementation of predesigned SEL practices, prioritizing expediency over relevance. To move toward more sustainable and contextually relevant practices, policy and investment decisions must balance evidence-based “universal” SEL knowledge and practices (mostly based on stable contexts), with local needs and priorities in each context. Achieving such alignment presents enormous challenges, requiring strong and sustained research–policy–practice partnerships built on trust, mutual respect, transparency, and accountability (Kim et al., 2022; Tubbs Dolan, 2017). These endeavors represent the next frontier in advancing SEL in CAC contexts.

SEL in CAC Contexts for Advancing Inclusive, Representative, and Generalizable Science

SEL programs and research should and do benefit *all* the world's children. To date, the study of SEL in CAC contexts has been largely isolated and, by some, is considered a separate research area from the broader field of SEL. It is often viewed as research on a

high-risk, select population, implying that findings from such a population may not be generalizable to the broader population. We reject this characterization. Children affected by conflict and crisis are not “selective” in numbers and nature. Globally, 1 in 5 children lives in conflict-affected areas (UNICEF, 2023), with at least 224 million, or 1 in 10 children in the world, being directly or indirectly affected by CACs (ECW, 2023). Recent events, such as the Russian invasion of Ukraine that displaced millions of Ukrainians in Europe, and earthquakes in Turkey and Syria that devastated both the refugee and host community populations, underscore that conflict and crisis do not discriminate—they can happen to any region and population. Moreover, exposure to conflict and crisis can pose a great risk not only to children’s mental and physical health but also to their development and learning—which is precisely the reason more theoretically grounded and empirically rigorous SEL research is necessary to better support their positive adaptation, development, and learning in CAC contexts.

To build an inclusive, representative, cumulative, and generalizable evidence base, systematic efforts of SEL researchers in both CAC and stable contexts are required. Research in CACs must balance building the evidence base that is consistent and comparable to existing SEL theories, frameworks, and evidence base, and reflects and represents the voices, perspectives, and lived realities of communities across diverse cultures and contexts. Expanding evidence on the “universal” SEL processes that are comparable and applicable across contexts will benefit the most vulnerable children by extending its reach and relevance. Mapping SECs across programs, contexts, and cultures within a common framework, as exemplified by the Taxonomy Project (Jones et al., 2020), is one way that SEL research in CACs can build on existing knowledge. On the one hand, this approach makes locally specific needs and priorities relevant and comparable across contexts, contributing to the expansion and enrichment of the broader knowledge base for SEL.

On the other hand, the broad SEL discourse needs to make explicit and intentional efforts to include and incorporate CAC research and practice. Simply imposing a

global SEL paradigm, based primarily on high-income, stable, and Western cultural contexts in which most research and theories are generated, onto all other contexts and conditions is not sufficient to advance SEL research as a field with global relevance for all children. Such effort requires revision and expansion of the current SEL paradigm. Inclusion of children’s experiences, development, and learning across a wide range of cultures and contexts affected by conflict and crisis not only helps the field better support the needs of the world’s most vulnerable children but also allows the field of SEL to grow into a truly inclusive, representative, and generalizable science.

KEY TAKEAWAY POINTS

- SEL can achieve positive results, even under the trying conditions of CACs.
- SEL programming and research in CACs need to strike a balance between leveraging existing knowledge from stable countries and generating new knowledge based on local, culture- and context-specific needs and priorities.
- To advance SEL program design and implementation, it is critical to understand and test how, for whom, and where SEL programming works in CACs.
- SEL in CAC contexts must solve challenges to program quantity (e.g., dosage, attendance) and program quality (e.g., lack of sequencing, limited teacher capacity).
- Improving SEL in CACs requires a new generation of research–practice–policy partnerships.

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